



ARJIT SEN

WOUND DEEPENS

1983: Private practice banned in Uttar Pradesh medical colleges and hospitals

1996: Central pay commission's recommendations made applicable to Delhi doctors

2003: State doctors demand parity with the central pay commission's recommendations. Mayawati revises non-practicing-allowance.

2005: Govt plans action against doctors doing private practice

2007: Court directs government to take action against doctors found indulging in private practice. Doctors take voluntary retirement.

MARCH 2008: Doctors threaten not to attend to VIPs after duty hours

APRIL 2008: Police raids CSMMU doctors to check private practice. Court pulls up government and CSMMU for private practice. In retaliation, doctors suspend health services at state's largest hospital.

package to be brought at par with that of national institutes', modern equipment, sanitary conditions, better amenities for students and making private practice optional for doctors.

But some feel even these measures wouldn't stem the exodus. "Despite higher pay and a better environment, specialists have been leaving the Sanjay Gandhi Post-Graduate Institute of Medical Research and the All India Institute of Medical Research," says former CTA president Dr G.K. Shukla. "But the government should treat doctors with respect, and create better facilities for teaching and research." Others blame the doctors for the messy state of affairs. "They devote more time to private practice and treat the poor with disregard," says MLC and Samajwadi Party leader Rakesh Singh Rana. The strike by CSMMU doctors was seen by patients as a way of blackmailing the government.

Their differences apart, the Uttar Pradesh Government will have to take urgent steps to resuscitate its health system and the medical fraternity will have to outgrow its leanings towards profiteering. Otherwise the common man will continue to suffer. ■

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